Northgate Physical Therapy

Kickoff notes for the new phone assistant · written by the clinic director after our onboarding call

To Voice agent deployment team

From Clinic Director, Northgate Physical Therapy

Re How we want the phones handled, plus the things I forgot to say on the call

Who we are

Thanks again for the call on Tuesday. As promised, here is everything in one place. Northgate is an outpatient physical therapy practice with two clinics, Westside (on Fulton Avenue, number 410) and Eastside (on Pine Road, number 77). Most of our patients come to us after surgery, a sports injury or a referral for back and neck pain. We see about 140 patients a week, and honestly the phones are the part of the job my front desk dreads, so we are glad to hand the routine calls over.

A first visit is always an initial evaluation, which runs 60 minutes, and every visit after that is a 45-minute follow-up. Please don't let anyone book a follow-up as their first visit; the therapist needs the evaluation to write the plan of care. Plans usually run two or three visits a week for four to eight weeks, and we never schedule more than three visits for the same patient in one week, even if they ask, because the insurance companies push back and frankly the tissue needs time to recover.

What the assistant should handle

New patients booking their evaluation, existing patients booking, moving or cancelling follow-ups, and general questions about hours and locations. Both clinics are open Monday to Friday, 7 AM to 7 PM. Westside also opens Saturday mornings from 8 to noon. Eastside is the only clinic with the therapy pool, and aquatic sessions run only on Tuesdays and Thursdays, so if someone's plan includes pool work, it has to be Eastside on one of those days.

When someone has just had surgery, timing matters a lot. Post-surgical patients need their first visit within 7 days of being discharged from the hospital, so if a caller mentions recent surgery, ask when they were discharged and treat getting them in that week as the priority, even if it means a less convenient time or the other clinic. If nothing fits inside the 7 days, don't just book the first open slot after; send it to the front desk so we can make room.

Paperwork and insurance, the short version

Most patients can come to us directly. The exception is Medicare: Medicare patients need a signed referral from their physician before the first visit, so for any caller on Medicare, ask whether they have the referral; if not, the assistant should still note their details but explain that we can only confirm the evaluation once the referral arrives, and ask them to have their doctor fax it.

Workers' compensation is a different world. Please don't book those at all. If a caller says their injury happened at work or mentions a claim number, transfer them to our case coordinator, who handles the authorization with the employer's insurer before anything is scheduled. On cost questions in general, the assistant shouldn't try to estimate anything; the front desk runs a benefits check and calls the patient back with their copay.

Things that worry me

A few of our patients are frail, and people sometimes call us before they call their doctor. If a caller says they had chest pain or real shortness of breath during or after their exercises, the assistant has to tell them to call 911, not book a visit. Same idea if someone fell and hit their head, or is now confused or vomiting after a fall: that is the emergency room, today. For ordinary soreness after a session, it's fine to book, but the assistant must not give advice about which exercises to stop or keep doing. Only a therapist can say that, so offer the earliest appointment or a callback from the patient's therapist.

The other thing is reschedules. Some patients move every single appointment and then wonder why they aren't improving. A patient can reschedule twice within one plan of care through the assistant. After the second, the next request should go to the front desk instead, so we can have a conversation about it. Cancellations don't count toward that, and we don't charge any cancellation fee, so please don't mention fees at all.

Questions my front desk gets every week

"Can my son book his own appointments? He's 16."

Under-18s have to be booked by a parent or guardian, and a parent or guardian has to be in the building for the evaluation. After that, teens can come to follow-ups on their own if the parent signed the consent form at the first visit.

"Do you have an interpreter?"

Yes. We use a phone interpreter service at no cost to the patient. The assistant should offer it to any caller who seems more comfortable in another language and note the language on the booking, so the therapist can have the interpreter on the line at the visit.

"Are you open on the holidays?"

Both clinics close on New Year's Day, Memorial Day, July 4th, Labor Day, Thanksgiving and the day after, and December 24th and 25th. Don't offer those days, even if the calendar shows openings, because the scheduling system doesn't always block them.

"Can I just come in today?"

We don't do walk-ins. Same-day follow-ups are fine if there's an opening, but a new patient evaluation needs at least one business day so the intake forms can be sent and returned.

Forwarded from our billing lead

From: Billing Lead · **Subject:** Re: phone assistant, one more thing

Hi both, one more for the list. Please make sure the assistant never tells a patient we “accept” or “take” a specific insurance plan. Plans change their networks mid-year and we got burned last spring. The right wording is that we will check their benefits and call them back before the first visit. Also, we stopped accepting Tricare as of October 1st, so if someone mentions Tricare, they should be told we are no longer in network for it and offered the self-pay rate conversation with the front desk.

Thanks!

Quick reference

Topic	Rule
Visit lengths	Initial evaluation 60 min; follow-ups 45 min
Locations	Westside, 410 Fulton Avenue (Saturday mornings too); Eastside, 77 Pine Road (pool)
Hours	Mon–Fri 7 AM – 7 PM; Westside Sat 8 AM – noon
Transfers	Front desk for anything unusual; case coordinator for workers’ comp

That should be everything. If anything here contradicts what I said on the call, this document wins. — Clinic Director